



Recovering Childhood: Play, Pedagogy, and the Rise of Psychological Knowledge in Contemporary Urban China

Author(s): Orna Naftali

Source: *Modern China*, Vol. 36, No. 6 (November 2010), pp. 589-616

Published by: [Sage Publications, Inc.](#)

Stable URL: <http://www.jstor.org/stable/25759531>

Accessed: 25/06/2014 01:58

Your use of the JSTOR archive indicates your acceptance of the Terms & Conditions of Use, available at <http://www.jstor.org/page/info/about/policies/terms.jsp>

JSTOR is a not-for-profit service that helps scholars, researchers, and students discover, use, and build upon a wide range of content in a trusted digital archive. We use information technology and tools to increase productivity and facilitate new forms of scholarship. For more information about JSTOR, please contact support@jstor.org.



Sage Publications, Inc. is collaborating with JSTOR to digitize, preserve and extend access to *Modern China*.

<http://www.jstor.org>

Recovering Childhood: Play, Pedagogy, and the Rise of Psychological Knowledge in Contemporary Urban China

Modern China

36(6) 589–616

© 2010 SAGE Publications

Reprints and permission: <http://www.sagepub.com/journalsPermissions.nav>

DOI: 10.1177/0097700410377594

<http://mcx.sagepub.com>



Orna Naftali¹

Abstract

In the past few decades, China has witnessed the emergence of a psychological discourse of childhood. This new discourse portrays children as persons with unique emotional needs and seeks to redefine childhood as a time of play and relaxation rather than study or toil. Drawing on the results of ethnographic fieldwork in Shanghai's schools and homes in 2004–2005, the present article describes the complex ways Shanghai's teachers and parents engage with this normalizing, developmental discourse. It argues that the rise of a psychological discourse of childhood signals a shift in Chinese modes of governing school and family life, and in current conceptualizations of the child-as-citizen and the child-as-subject in postsocialist, urban China.

Keywords

China, childhood, psychology, subjectivity, education

¹Hebrew University of Jerusalem, Jerusalem, Israel

Corresponding Author:

Orna Naftali, The Louis Frieberg Center for East Asian Studies and The Harry S. Truman Research Institute for the Advancement of Peace, Hebrew University of Jerusalem, Mt. Scopus, Jerusalem 91905, Israel
Email: norna@mscc.huji.ac.il

"Are children persons or objects?" asks the author of an essay published in China under the title "Erroneous Views of the Child in Family Education" (Wang, 2002: 104). It might seem a peculiar question, but the writer, the former deputy head of the Wuhan Education Research Institute, is not being rhetorical. In fact, he observes, quite a few contemporary parents in China "are not entirely sure of the correct answer." Deploing the "commonplace tendency" to "treat children as the showcase of the family," while pressuring them to devote a majority of their time to academic work and skill-enhancement activities, Wang concludes his essay by pleading with readers to "advance with the times" and to recognize that children are not "small-sized adults," but persons with unique emotional needs which vary according to their age.

Part of a 2002 edited volume published by the Chinese Ministry of Education (MOE), the All-China Women's Federation (ACWF), and the Communist Youth League, this particular essay is typical of a new, influential strain of discourse about children and their education in contemporary urban China. In the past two decades or so, a growing number of official statements, legal codes, school reform plans, teachers' manuals, and parenting books and magazines have been promoting the idea that if Chinese children are to develop fully and healthily, they must be allowed to experience a "proper" childhood, defined as a time of leisure and play, rather than study and toil. Allowing children to experience a so-called "happy childhood," these publications suggest, is crucial both to the well-being of individual children as well as to the successful construction of a "stable, harmonious" society and a "strong, vital" Chinese nation.

Why is the postsocialist party-state in China so keen on advancing the idea of a normalized, joyful childhood? To what extent are contemporary Chinese discourses of education influenced by modern, liberal constructions of the "self-cultivating, self-governing" child currently circulating elsewhere in the world? And how do urban Chinese teachers and parents of different socioeconomic backgrounds engage with ostensibly universalistic principles of child development and child psychology in their day-to-day practices?

Drawing on the results of ethnographic fieldwork in schools and homes in the city of Shanghai in 2004–2005, and on an analysis of textual sources published in China in the past decade or so, the present article addresses these questions while tracing the links between the endorsement of a pedagogy that stresses the "happiness" and "emotional needs" of the young; China's increasing integration within the global market economy; recent developments in the governing logic of the Chinese Communist Party (CCP); and changing notions of the child and the person in postsocialist, urban China.

In recent years, a growing number of studies have begun to document the changing nature of urban childhood in China of the reform era (1978–present). As a result of liberal market reforms and the introduction of the One-Child family

policy in the late 1970s, a number of scholars suggest, Chinese singletons have increasingly been made to bear the entire weight of their parents' (and grandparents') "hopes, expectations and aspirations," primarily in the area of schoolwork and academic achievements (Croll, 2006: 201; see also Anagnost, 1997, 2008; Chee, 2000; Fong, 2004b, 2007; Milwertz, 1997; Woronov, 2007). In Chinese cities, recent ethnographic studies report an "increased attentiveness to the exhaustive use of children's time," now filled with a plethora of extracurricular activities designed to enhance the only-child's bodily and psychological capabilities (Anagnost, 1997: 196; Champagne, 1992; Fong, 2004b; Woronov, 2007).

To some, the recent attempt to improve the "quality" (*suzhi*) of children's mentality and physique, particularly among urban Chinese families of the new middle class, signifies the ascendance of a so-called "neoliberal" discourse of subject formation in postsocialist China. Much like their peers elsewhere in the world, Chinese only-children are now encouraged to become "self-making," "self-governing" subjects, who can later turn into successful laborers and consumers in a global market economy (Anagnost, 2004; Greenhalgh and Winckler, 2005; Woronov, 2007). In the process, however, children's lives are said to undergo intensive "regimentation" and "managerialization," while Chinese childhood is arguably "in danger of becoming a time of ceaseless labor and struggle" (Anagnost, 2008: 64; Greenhalgh and Winckler, 2005).¹

Building on the results of this valuable body of work, the present article highlights the importance of a different type of universalizing discourse on children and their education in contemporary urban China. Alongside—or indeed in response to—the "production of a highly disciplined childhood" dedicated to improving the "entrepreneurial" qualities of the urban only-child (see Greenhalgh and Winckler, 2005: 243), there also has emerged an equally influential discursive strain, which seeks to challenge existing pedagogical practices in China by emphasizing children's unique natures and distinct developmental requirements, including the requirement that they experience a "joyful, stress-free childhood."

This discourse should not be taken as merely a welcome attempt to acknowledge the "true needs" of children or to recover the proper notion of childhood in contemporary urban China. Indeed, to postulate that would be to ignore the fact that a concept of childhood as a joyful, carefree time is in itself a product of Western, modern thinking rather than a necessary feature of childhood everywhere (Burman, 1996: 49; Field, 1995: 65; James, Jenks, and Prout, 1998: 19; Stephens, 1995: 14–15; Heywood, 2001: 24; Walkerdine, 2005: 16–17; Woodhead, 1997). Instead, I suggest that we view the emergent idea of a playful, normalized childhood as part of an ongoing transformation in Chinese constructions of "personhood and power, social order and disorder"

(Scheper-Hughes and Sargent, 1998: 1), albeit a transformation riddled by paradoxes and contradictions.

In advancing psychological principles of childrearing and education, contemporary government, academic, and media publications are providing Chinese teachers and parents with a novel vocabulary for speaking and thinking about the young, while also inspiring new “desires, anxieties, and subjectivities” among adults and children alike (Rose, 1989: 149; Walkerdine, 1984: 164). The result, it could be argued, is a standardization of childhood and an increasing individualization of children in postsocialist urban China. These processes, however, are fraught with significant difficulties, which stem from the nature of the country’s education and evaluation system; from the conflicting aspirations of urban parents who wish to associate themselves with a middle-class sensibility; and from the influence of a native ethos, which considers study and toil as the central moral duties of a filial child.

A Child Is a Human Being in a Class by Itself

A growing number of historical studies indicate that a notion of childhood as a stage of life distinguishable from adulthood had existed in China prior to the modern era (see Bai, 2005b; Hsiung, 2005; Kinney, 1995, 2004; Nylan, 2003; Wicks and Avril, 2002). A majority of scholars are also in agreement, however, that orthodox Confucian perspectives placed little value on the childhood stage itself, frequently discouraged aimless play and unrestrained activity even in the very young, and stressed that education should instill adult standards in children as early as possible, ideally from the age of seven or eight *sui* (six or seven years old by Western reckoning) (Bai, 2005a: 10; Dardess, 1991: 79; Hsiung, 2005: 119; Kinney, 1995: 12; Saari, 1990: 45; Wicks and Avril, 2002: 4).

It was only in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries that a modern conceptualization of childhood as a series of “normalized” developmental stages, and of children as a “unique type of persons” who require “playful, spontaneous” activities to maintain their “healthy growth,” was first introduced to China from the West (see Anagnost, 1997; Fernsebner, 2003; Jones, 2002; Leung, 1995; Nylan, 2003). At a time of major national crisis and semicolonial occupation, leading May Fourth intellectuals regarded the proper rearing and development of China’s young as a necessary condition for nation-building and modernization (Jones, 2002: 700; Farquhar, 1999: 30, 61; Pease, 1995: 287). It was also at this time that Chinese pioneers of child psychology (such as Chen Heqin, for instance) sought to establish that “a child is not just ‘a small man,’” but possesses a “psychology [that] is different from that of adults” (cited in Borevskaya, 2001: 36).

Psychological principles, particularly those grounded in Soviet theories, continued to guide Chinese pedagogical thinking for a brief period after the establishment of the People's Republic (Chan, 1985; Liu, 1982; Tardif and Miao, 2000). Yet the notion that children possess unique needs or that childhood ought to be a time of amusement and leisure was soon to be eclipsed by the radical ideology of class struggle. During the chaotic decade of the Cultural Revolution (1966–1976), even young children were called upon to play the role of “vanguard fighters” in the struggle for the construction of a new socialist society (Donald, 1999: 82, 95). Moreover, mental illnesses were frequently cast as problems of deviant political thinking to be addressed through reeducation rather than psychological health care (Chang et al., 2005; see also Liu, 1982; Tardif and Miao, 2000).

It was not until 1978, when the CCP turned from an emphasis on socialism and revolution to “science” and “modernity,” that psychology once again started to gain ground in China (Tardif and Miao, 2000: 68). With the advancement of liberal economic reforms and increasing standards of living in urban areas, more and more Chinese urbanites, particularly those of a middle-class background, are now turning to psychological counseling in order “to grapple with their personal and family problems,” many of which are said to stem from the weakening of communal support networks and the increasingly competitive and stressful lives generated by the market economy (Zhang, 2008; Chang et al., 2005; see also Xinhua News Agency, 2008). Concomitantly, public and private psychological consultation services, hotlines, radio call-in programs, as well as professional advice literature, have all grown exponentially in China during the past few decades (Erwin, 2000; Farquhar, 2001; Feng, 2003; Liu, 1982).

In step with this so-called “mass-individualized psychotherapy and psychological counseling movement” (see Zhang, 2008), recent years have also begun to witness the (re)emergence of the notion that children are not “short, light-bodied adults,” as the author whose words opened the present article suggests, but “constitute human beings in a class by themselves.” As such, they are said to possess unique personality features that must be understood and catered to (see, e.g., *China Daily*, 2005; Cui and Huang, 2002; Wang, 2002; Xu, 2004; Zeng, 2004; Zhou, 1998). A survey of government, academic, and media sources published in China in the past decade or so reveals that this growing recognition of children's distinct mental needs is often portrayed as a crucial step in solving what is thought to be one of the most pressing problems facing Chinese urban singletons today: emotional difficulties caused by excessive pressure at school and high expectations at home.

Particularly since the late 1990s, China's state-run media have paid much attention to what has been depicted as a national malaise of “too much homework,

frequent testing, and heavy parental demands,” all of which are said to be detrimental to the “mental health” of the nation’s children. Quoting “statistical surveys” and “scientific” studies which show that China’s urban young now suffer from a range of acute mental problems (from “internet addiction,” to “psychosomatic skin diseases,” to “suicidal tendencies”), a growing number of alarmist reports in Chinese (as well as foreign) media further suggest that these problems stem from the fact that a “majority [of Chinese urban children] spend longer hours at school than their parents spend at work,” have “little time to play,” and consequently “are experiencing *joyless childhoods*” (*People’s Daily*, 2007, emphasis added; see also AFP, 2004; *China Daily*, 2005; Cha, 2007; Guo, 2004; *People’s Daily*, 2005; Reynolds, 2008).

The Chinese government appears to recognize this as a major problem as well, for in the past decade or so, it has begun to introduce various measures to alleviate the pressure and protect the “mental health of schoolchildren” in accordance with the “development characteristics ... of [their] growth” (Communist Party of China, 2000: 231–32). China’s 1999 Education for Quality (*suzhi jiaoyu*) reform plan calls, for instance, for a limit on the number of school hours and examinations, as well as the amount of work assigned to young students (Communist Party of China, 2000).² School reforms at the regional and municipal levels, such as Shanghai’s 2004 Second Phase Curriculum Reform (*erqi kegai*), accordingly include such measures as starting the school day half an hour later (at 8 AM rather 7:30 AM) and reducing the duration of each primary school lesson from 45 to 35 minutes, so that children will have “more free time to play and relax” (Yang, 2004). Shanghai’s 2004 Regulations on the Protection of Minors likewise urges schools to “lighten students’ workload” and exhorts caregivers to allow children to “receive sufficient time for rest and recreation (*yule*),” while “paying attention to [their] physical and emotional changes according to the different age stages they are in” (Shanghai People’s Congress Standing Committee, 2004).

It is not just the importance of rest and recreation that is being emphasized, however. A central theme in various school reform plans introduced in recent years under the banner of *suzhi jiaoyu* is the notion that young students need to enjoy their learning experience. Chinese pedagogy, a 2001 teacher training manual argues, has “traditionally” stressed the “knowledge” (*zhi*) aspect of learning, while ignoring its “emotional” (*qing*) side (Fu and Xu, 2001: 43). However, the manual suggests that “modern, psychological research” has shown that the latter aspect is in fact “equally important.” Therefore, teachers should pay attention not only to students’ grades but also to their “emotional states” while striving to create a “relaxed, cheerful” class atmosphere that fits the unique attributes of young children (see, e.g., Cui and Huang, 2002: 227–29, 233–43; Cui, 1999: 73–76; Wei, 2000: 48).

According to Chinese government statements in the past decade or so, such measures are necessary not only so that individual students will be able to “develop lively and actively,” but also because children’s psychological and physical health constitutes a “precondition” and “a manifestation of the strong vitality of the Chinese nation” (Communist Party of China, 2000: 231–32). Particularly since the mid-2000s, the state-run media in China (see, e.g., Tian, 2005) have also begun to frame the problem of children’s poor psychological health as a major obstacle to the successful construction of a socialist “harmonious society” (*hexie shehui*)—now a key term in CCP policy statements and directives to cadres. As recently noted by Luigi Tomba, the CCP’s discourse of “harmony” (as the ultimate goal of its social policies) frequently portrays “individual behavior” and responsible self-governance as key means to the removal of the “economic, social, or behavioral causes” of underlying contradictions and threatening social problems (Tomba, 2009).

Contemporary psychologists in China have been following suit by arguing that the formation of a “politically stable society,” where there are few “negative social conflicts,” is ultimately bound up with the creation of a “harmonious (*hexie*) personality,” characterized by such features as “high levels of self-awareness,” “emotional stability,” “an optimistic outlook,” and “appropriate behavioral responses” to frustrating situations in familial, social, and professional life (see, e.g., He, 2007; Zhang and Zhou, 2008; Guangdong sheng kepu xinxi zhongxin, 2008).

The promotion of the “balanced mental development” of Chinese citizens (old and young alike) in turn requires the introduction of systematic psychological tutoring. According to official statistics, there are currently fewer than two psychiatrists for every 100,000 people in China, far lower than the world average of four doctors (*China Daily*, 2010). Participants at a recent Chinese Academy of Social Sciences (CASS) colloquium on “psychology and harmonious society” expressed concern about the lack of professional care and urged the establishment of a more effective psychological service system in the country. This, they suggested, would be conducive not only “to the rise of the public health level” and to “improving the living quality” of Chinese citizens, but also to “upgrading working productivity . . . ensuring the society’s stability and unity . . . and promoting its harmony” (CASS, 2007; see also CAST, 2007).³

Paying Attention to Children’s Emotional Needs

To enable the creation of psychologically fit citizens who can contribute to the construction of a stable, harmonious society, China’s current educational reforms reach as far as the child’s soul (cf. Rose, 1989). For instance, the Chinese government has recently published an eight-year national plan to install “mental

health counseling offices” in urban as well as rural schools across the country (Xinhua News Agency, 2008). In cities such as Beijing and Shanghai, schools have also been required to introduce “psychological training classes” to the regular curriculum in order to “strengthen students’ mental health” (Shanghai People’s Congress Standing Committee, 2004; Xinhua News Agency, 2003). Reportedly, such classes are meant to help young learners develop “correct self-awareness and self-consciousness” and to encourage them to “happily receive psychological guidance throughout their lives” (Wei, 2000: 50; Sun, 2001: 65; Xiaoxuesheng xinli, 2000: 1–6; and see also Borevskaya, 2001: 46).

According to a fourth-grade teacher’s manual on how “to nurture the psychological quality of primary school students,” these goals can be achieved, for instance, by asking children to prepare a list of their abilities and shortcomings based on their subjective evaluations, and then have them compare their responses to the assessments of their teachers, class peers, and parents. Exercises such as these, the manual explains, will not only instruct children on how to “objectively analyze their personality and their relationship with others,” but also help them to better “control their emotions and behavior” (Xiaoxuesheng xinli, 2000; see also Borevskaya, 2001: 46).

Significantly, the current emphasis on the mental health of young students has given frontline Chinese educators a new role as well, conceived in terms of therapeutics of childhood (Rose, 1989: 172). For instance, primary school teachers are now expected to analyze the unique traits of each student’s basic psychological circumstances and to record the results of this analysis in a “psychological file” (*xinli dang’an*) compiled for each and every child (Cui and Huang, 2002: 253; Zhou, 2005). According to the authors of the 2002 academic volume *Theories of Psychological Education for Quality*, this personal file should consist of “the circumstances (*qingkuang*) of the student’s family members”; the child’s “individual history (in terms of academic achievements, behavior, thinking/ideology [*sixiang*], and illnesses)”; “an analysis of the student’s personal character, cognitive abilities, and emotional tendencies”; as well as a “psychological consultation log” (Cui and Huang, 2002: 253).

Notably, neither of the two primary schools I studied in Shanghai offered students psychological training lessons at the time I conducted my fieldwork in 2004–2005, though one vice-principal proudly pointed to a new sign above a room designated to become the school’s “psychology office” (*xinli shi*).⁴ Conversations I held with more than forty Shanghai school staff and frontline teachers nonetheless reflected the increasing recognition that educators should “pay attention not only to students’ grades but also to their psychological well-being.” A good teacher, several informants explained, is “sensitive to children’s emotional needs” and provides them not only with knowledge but also with

the proper tools to “better understand themselves” (*liaojie ziji*) and to attain “healthy emotional development.”

When I asked for examples of how a teacher can achieve this goal, several informants explained that when a student is doing badly at school, a teacher should avoid the previously common habit of publicly shaming the child in front of his or her peers and instead “try to understand the unique circumstances” that may have led to the student’s poor performance. Has the child lost faith in her ability to succeed due to some recent setbacks? Or is there some trouble at home that may be affecting her emotional state and consequently her ability to focus on her schoolwork? Analyzing a child’s unique “emotional tendencies” and “psychological circumstances” rather than rushing to scold her in front of her peers had apparently become the order of the day at the two Shanghai schools I studied.

In several instances, particularly during Chinese and Moral Education classes, teachers were also observed asking children to “discuss their feelings” and “share their personal experiences” with their class peers (see Naftali, 2008: 261). These and other changes, explained school staff and educators, were all part of a recent attempt to move from a so-called “traditional,” “exam-oriented education” (*yingshi jiaoyu*) to an ostensibly more “modern, advanced” pedagogy that stresses the affective needs of young learners as much as their academic achievements. The Communist Party secretary at one of the primary schools I studied (a fashionable woman in her late twenties) noted for instance: “Right now, we are in the midst of absorbing some of the more positive elements of Western education systems, including a greater emphasis on the *needs* of the students. As you can see, we are adopting a much more *scientific, rational* notion of education,” she added emphatically.

As can be expected though, the reality was slightly more complex than teachers and staff portrayed it. During close to 100 hours of class observations I conducted at the two primary schools, I often witnessed different teachers across various subjects and grades praising children for their accomplishments, while criticism was noticeably rare. At the same time, however, I also had a chance to observe occasional instances of public scolding of children who did poorly on exams. Judging by anecdotes related to me by parents,⁵ it appeared that such practices continued to exist in other schools across the city as well. A well-educated Shanghai mother in her late thirties recounted, for instance, how her son came home from school one day and told her that his teacher had severely criticized one of the other children for getting a mere 70 on an exam. The child in question was apparently made to stand in front of his peers and harshly scolded for making “the entire class lose face.” After relating this particular incidence, my informant thoughtfully added:

From what I know about recent reforms in Shanghai, teachers are not supposed to do that anymore. They are supposed to respect students and pay attention not only to their grades and studies, but also to their feelings. Still, you might say things are a little bit better now than what they used to be. When I was at school, teachers often criticized children and humiliated them in front of the whole class. At least nowadays, they know what they are doing is wrong, even if they don't always practice it. Back then, *they weren't even aware of it.*

What this mother's words reveal, then, is that the notion that children have unique psychological needs has indeed been gaining ground in the discourses (though not always in the practices) of city educators. In my conversations with Shanghai primary school teachers and staff, informants further acknowledged that a central need of children is to find pleasure in their school work. "Unlike adults," a Shanghai schoolteacher explained, "young children have short attention spans and cannot force themselves to study." Therefore, "it is important that they enjoy themselves in the classroom."

Learning Should Be Fun

Class observations at the two Shanghai primary schools I studied indeed revealed a new emphasis on the inclusion of "fun" activities, involving games, toys, storytelling, dancing, singing, and performances of sketches, in lesson plans across the grades and in various subjects. During specially designated lesson segments, children were also allowed to get up from their desks, walk around the room, and even talk without permission—practices that, according to some of the older teachers, were "unheard of" prior to the introduction of Shanghai's recent school reforms.

A local education scholar who studies the impact of introducing innovative teaching methods to math lessons further suggested that the current emphasis on "joyful education" (*kuaile jiaoyu*) in Shanghai primary schools may be part of a broader shift in the conceptualization of childhood in China. "Until recently," she noted, "Chinese primary schools used to be almost indistinguishable from middle schools. Just like their older colleagues, six-, seven-, and eight-year-olds had to spend long hours in the classroom, received a heavy load of homework assignments and had many tests." The situation was "slowly changing," she noted, since Chinese educators "have now come to realize that they need to adjust the curriculum and instructional activities to the unique interests and developmental needs of children." This particular recognition, explained an assistant to the vice-principal who also taught Chinese at a Shanghai primary

school, has had some practical implications as well: “Whereas a few years back,” she noted, her third-grade students would be assigned topics such as “the importance of labor” or “doing good deeds,” nowadays, she would ask children to write about “things that actually interest them,” such as their “favorite cartoon character,” for instance.

There was a limit, however, to the extent to which individual teachers could adjust the curriculum to suit the needs and interests of young learners. For, as quite a few teachers noted in visible frustration, the contents of each lesson, as well as the subjects themselves, were all “determined from above.” Moreover, teachers and staff also testified that primary schools in Shanghai continued to frequently test children on their knowledge, forcing teachers to assign large amounts of homework and to focus on exam preparation rather than on making the learning experience more enjoyable for children.⁶ A middle-aged Shanghai teacher with more than 15 years of experience succinctly summarized the situation:

They talk about reducing students’ workload (*jianfu*), but children are still required to learn too many things in too short a time . . . In reality then, many teachers follow the principle of “Vigorously hail Education for Quality, hold firmly to exam-oriented education” (*Suzhi jiaoyu hande honghong lieli, yingshi jiaoyu zhuade zhazha shishi*).

“You Can Barely Call It a Childhood Anymore!”

Partly as a result of this situation, many Shanghai children appeared to endure heavy academic pressure. Indeed, a statement I repeatedly heard during my conversations with teachers and parents was “Chinese children suffer too much nowadays!” (*Zhongguo de haizi tai ku le!*). Mothers I spoke to reported, for instance, that their school-aged child had to wake up at 6:30 in the morning, stay at school until 4:30 in the afternoon, and then return home only to face a large amount of homework assignments and tests to prepare for. By the time they have reached fourth grade, many children have failed to finish their schoolwork before 9:00 or 10:00 in the evening, sometimes even having to wake up early in the morning to complete their unfinished tasks. As a result, some of the well-educated mothers I spoke to complained that their children were in “a state of constant exhaustion.”

In the eyes of Shanghai’s schoolteachers, the problem lay at least in part in the behavior of parents themselves. Some teachers told me, for instance, that while they had done their best to reduce students’ homework in order to comply with the new guidelines, “many of their students’ parents” objected to this change because, in their minds, it could jeopardize their child’s chances of

succeeding in future exams. Apparently, several well-educated mothers even started to assign their children extra homework to “keep them on their toes.”⁷ A 55-year-old Shanghai mother, who served as a volunteer at a local parents association, elaborated:

Ten or even fifteen years ago, parental pressure started when kids entered middle school just before going to university, but these days it already starts in kindergarten. The only form of entertainment kids have nowadays is playing the piano, and even that is forced on them: some parents think that if their child can't play the piano, he is not as good as the neighbors' child. I've even heard of children who cut their hands so that they wouldn't have to play anymore! If you ask children today what they're going to do during the school break, they'll tell you all they want to do is sleep . . . *Sleep* is children's way of having fun now! Their childhood years are so unhappy you can barely call it a “childhood” any more!

As she and others explained, and as noted by a number of recent ethnographic studies on childrearing and education in China (see, e.g., Chee, 2000; Fong, 2004b; Woronov, 2007, 2008), the difficulty largely lay in the country's selection and evaluation system. To gain acceptance to a good university, a student had to do well on the National College Entrance Examination (the NCEE, or the *gao kao*). But in order to achieve that coveted goal, he or she first had to attend a good middle school, and admission depended on the results of the middle school entrance examination (the *zhong kao*). In the minds of many Chinese parents, doing well on the NCEE determined not only one's chances of entering a top university but also of securing a good position later in life. In reality, that was not always true,⁸ but parents of different socioeconomic backgrounds nonetheless continued to cherish this dream for their child, pressuring him or her to study hard in hope of “raising a dragon”—a talented, smart, successful (only) offspring (see also Croll, 2006; Fong, 2004b; Milwertz, 1997; Woronov, 2007, 2008).

In practice then, parents—particularly well-educated professionals—were often caught in a bind. While many of the educated mothers I spoke to, especially those who reported consuming psychological advice literature, pushed their children to do well at school, they also confessed that they “felt truly sorry” for their child's “bitter suffering” due to the pressure. Some also felt that, in adopting the recommendations of child psychology experts, they were in fact displaying a higher “quality” (*suzhi*) and a more “civilized” parenting style than that of parents with lower levels of education. A Shanghai office worker married to

a wealthy entrepreneur noted, for instance, that she “often” consulted articles by Chinese and Western child psychologists in order “to understand better her child’s wishes and needs.” At the same time, she also emphasized that this was *not* typical of parents in other parts of the country. In China’s more “backward (*luohou*) areas,” she commented with unmistakable contempt, “people treat their children in shocking ways,” which she herself “could not really understand.” Unlike “these parents,” she assured me, “we [in Shanghai] raise our children *with great care*” (see Naftali, 2009: 98–99).

When I traveled to a suburban primary school not far from the city, I met with a primary school teacher who held a similar view. These days, she acknowledged, childrearing guides and magazines have become more available to many Chinese urbanites. However, the parents of children at her school, most of whom were “simple workers” with “relatively low levels of education,” did not consult this sort of literature, she claimed. “What you read about in these books and magazines is just not relevant to them. It simply doesn’t reflect their lives,” my school informant insisted.

My own conversations with several working-class mothers largely corroborated these claims. For instance, I found that mothers who worked in blue-collar occupations, had no more than a high-school education, and were born and raised in either a rural area or a small town outside Shanghai were more likely to report that they had never read books or magazines on childrearing and education.⁹ These less-educated informants also did not express the same concerns for their child’s “feelings” or “healthy mental development” recommended by such publications. Instead, they expressed the fear that children who did not work hard enough at their studies would “never amount to much” later in life.

Significantly, such concerns were also shared by some of the well-educated mothers I spoke to, who frequently reported purchasing extra exercise books and worksheets for their sons or daughters, enrolling them in complementary after-school lessons, and sending them to special classes designed to develop the child’s talents and abilities.¹⁰ A 37-year-old Shanghai academic, who told me she regularly consumed psychological childrearing advice published in books and magazines, expressed her belief that “parents should pay attention to children’s emotional education.” She further complained that “these days, parents and children don’t really have much time to talk to each other,” since “children spend most of their time at school, and when they come home, spend more time reading textbooks and doing homework.” Yet the same informant also mentioned that her eight-year-old son was currently participating in a number of after-school classes, including drawing, calligraphy, computers, and English lessons (“he used to learn the piano, but didn’t have time for it anymore,” she noted). These

particular classes, she emphasized, were largely chosen based on their usefulness in terms of the boy's future school career, not necessarily because he was interested in them.

A Shanghai book editor in her late thirties similarly told me she "often consulted Chinese and foreign advice literature" on issues related to childrearing and education and also stated that, "unlike other parents," she and her husband placed their child's "happiness" and "unfettered development" over his academic success. Yet like the previous informant, this mother also enrolled her seven-year-old son in various enrichment classes. Between regular school assignments, studying for exams, taking lessons in art and conversational English, and competing in Chinese chess tournaments during the weekends, the boy—whose room was filled with games and toys—in fact had little time left for spontaneous play.¹¹

Some Shanghai children apparently did not hesitate to publicly voice their objections to the situation. In 2004, for instance, a large number of participants at Shanghai's Fifth Conference of Young Pioneers had reportedly submitted public petitions, in which they "voiced demands that parents and school officials start listening to *the experts*," "let up the pressure," and provide them with "an easier environment for study and life," thereby allowing them "*to have a childhood*" (cited in *China Daily*, 2004, emphasis added). Shanghai teachers I spoke to certainly acknowledged children's plight in this regard, yet when it came to their own children, were visibly conflicted about the notion that childhood ought to be a time of leisure and play rather than pressure and toil. The following statement, made by a Shanghai art teacher who is also the mother of a primary school student, demonstrates the deep ambivalence even among those in charge of the dissemination of a "normalized" vision of childhood:

Children really work too hard nowadays. Today, in class, a student handed me a particularly good drawing, so I praised him and asked him rather casually: "Does your mother send you to art classes on the weekends?"

"I don't have time for that," he told me. "I already have a full day of lessons on Saturdays *and* Sundays."

Mind you, these are not drawing or singing lessons or anything like that. We are talking about English, computers, math, physics, and chemistry lessons for six- and seven-year-olds! It's very tiring for a child . . . My son only has English lessons during the weekends. That's because he will be tested on it later on and also because it's very important to know English these days. He also plays the piano, but we don't force him to participate in competitions. We don't want to pressure him too much, you see.

Somewhat ironically, the Shanghai education scholar who studies the introduction of more age-appropriate, hands-on teaching methods to primary school math lessons likewise admitted that, as a parent of a fourth-grader, she herself had mixed feelings about the goals of Shanghai's current school reforms:

My son's school has all sorts of fun, after-school activities, which also contribute to his development. The children there are all rather lively and bold; they're not afraid to talk to adults and have relatively broad knowledge . . . but I'm bit concerned about next year. I'm still not sure whether I should let him participate in these sorts of activities anymore. You might say I'm conflicted, and I'm not the only one . . . The truth is that we do have reforms, but not all schools actually conform to them. And since everyone has to take an exam at the end, my son might be disadvantaged later on if he doesn't get enough practice at this early stage.

As can be seen from these statements, the concerns of well-educated Shanghai parents about the future career chances of their only offspring often led them to disregard the experts' prescriptions for fostering a "a mentally healthy child" able to enjoy a "carefree childhood." As noted before, such concerns also conflicted with the desire of some educated parents of means to associate themselves with a presumably more civilized parenting style, deemed suitable for a middle-class sensibility.

Membership in a certain age group may have also played a part in Chinese mothers' attitudes toward the psychological discourse of a "happy, healthy childhood." It has been suggested, for instance, that educated Chinese parents born after the introduction of the One-Child family policy in 1979 are often determined to allow their children to enjoy a "happy and carefree childhood" filled with "play and fun," not only because this sort of parental attitude is regarded as more modern and scientific but also because these younger parents—most of whom are only-children—grew up with the pressure of being better and smarter than their peers (see Guan, 2009). Notably, the Shanghai mothers who took part in my study did not belong to this particular age cohort (their ages ranged from 33 to 52 years). Similar childhood experiences of informants who were raised during the tumultuous decade of the Cultural Revolution (1966–1976) nonetheless affected their parental attitudes in significant ways. For instance, mothers in their mid- to late-forties frequently did not have a chance to receive a full course of basic education, not to mention the opportunity to attend university, and were therefore less supportive of the current emphasis on tending to the mental needs of children. Deprived of a proper education in their childhood and youth, these mothers arguably wanted

their own children to do better than they had, even if that meant missing out on a happy childhood as defined by the norms of modern psychological science (see Anagnost, 2008; Chee, 2000; Davis and Sensenbrenner, 2000; Fong, 2004b; Milwertz, 1997).

Finally, parents' insistence that children spend a majority of their free time studying or enhancing their skills rather than playing or relaxing may have also been related to the enduring influence of the ethos of filial piety (*xiao*), grounded in the Confucian principle of reciprocal family relations. A number of recent studies (see, e.g., Chao, 1994; Stafford, 1995; Wu, 1996; Fong, 2007; Kipnis, 2008) have shown, for instance, that Chinese parents often expect that a child work hard at his or her schoolwork from a relatively early age. This expectation, these studies claim, is in turn related to the conviction that parents have a "moral duty" to train the child to succeed in school, while children must ensure that their parents' "sacrifices had meaning," and repay their mothers and fathers for their care and investment by working as hard as they can in order to obtain good grades and later on a successful career (see, in particular, Fong, 2004a: 634–45; Kipnis, 2008: 215). The intense pressure on urban (only) children to do well at school, it has been suggested, may also stem from the relatively common view that a child's academic success serves as a form of future guarantee that the parents would receive sufficient care—emotionally, financially, and/or physically—when they reach old age (see Fong, 2004b; Milwertz, 1997; Whyte, 2004).

My work among contemporary Shanghai families reveals the persistence of similar beliefs among parents of various educational and occupational backgrounds. A majority of well-educated Shanghai mothers reported, for instance, that while their school-age child did not spend much time playing, he or she was also under no obligation to perform any domestic chores. One mother explained, "[My 12-year-old daughter] doesn't do anything around the house and I don't want her to either. Her main responsibility is to study ... If she does well at school that's enough for me" (cited in Naftali, 2009: 91).¹²

The idea that a child's "main duty in life" is to engage in arduous schoolwork was also evident among Shanghai mothers of blue-collar occupations and relatively low levels of education. Like better-educated mothers, these women reported putting much pressure on their sons and daughters to do well in school. In contrast to the former group, however, Shanghai mothers of low levels of education did not make any apologies about their child's lack of "play time" or her "bitter suffering" at school. To these less-educated women, the most important issue was that their son or daughter become "a person of ability" (*nengli*) with "a promising future" (*you chuxi*), even if that meant forcing the

child to do his/her homework late at night despite complaints of fatigue, or severely punishing the child for a bad grade, regardless of his or her feelings.

Based on these statements, then, we may conclude that while a shift in the notion of what constitutes a “proper childhood” may indeed be underway, at least among some well-educated Shanghai parents of white-collar professions, this particular group of parents was also the most ambivalent about the messages conveyed to them by psychological experts, education specialists, and government officials. On the one hand, Shanghai mothers who aspired to associate themselves with a middle-class civility seemed to have internalized the notion that “modern, scientific” parenthood necessitates the knowledge of “international developments” in the field of education (see Donald and Zheng, 2008: 74), and recognized that children have unique emotional and developmental needs, including the need for sufficient leisure and play.¹³ On the other hand, many of these well-educated women also maintained that taking music, English, or calligraphy lessons was a necessary condition for their (only) child’s success in an increasingly competitive academic and job market (see also Anagnost, 2008; Chee, 2000; Fong, 2004b; Woronov, 2007, 2008). Moreover, as in the case of their working-class peers, the parental attitudes of these well-educated mothers were also affected by the persistent influence of the notion of filial piety, which deems that childhood should be a time of hard work rather than aimless play. As a result, Shanghai parents who took part in the study frequently sacrificed their children’s “happiness” and “mental well-being” when it came to the all-important issue of schoolwork.

Discussion and Conclusion

The conceptualization of children’s basic needs and the notion of what constitutes a proper childhood are undergoing a significant shift in contemporary urban China. Whereas late-imperial, Confucian perspectives maintained that children should act with adult seriousness, and revolutionary discourses of the 1960s–1970s demanded that China’s young suppress their distinct “childish” characteristics and bear social and political responsibilities similar to those of adults, reform-era discourses in contrast tend to promote the notion that children are distinct from adults in terms of their “natural” developmental needs, including the need for a “happy, carefree” childhood.

The current attempt to recover the “true” meaning of childhood in reform-era China resonates with the sort of child-centered, developmental discourse which flourished, albeit briefly, in China of the 1920s–1930s. Clearly, both discourses

share a close linkage between children's happiness and healthy development and broader questions of civility, modernity, and national identity. The resemblance may not be accidental, for these particular constructions of the child were produced under parallel conditions of relative openness to foreign ideas and products, and of increasing integration within global capitalism (see Anagnost, 1997, 2008; Jones, 2002).

However, in contrast to the liberal-minded discourses of the May Fourth era, which, for a short period, flourished in a relatively open political environment, present-day Chinese conceptualizations of the "normal, happy" child have been formed under the rule of a nondemocratic party-state, which in the past two decades or so has increasingly privatized various social services, while seeking to reestablish its legitimacy amid growing social and economic tensions. It is partly in this context that we must understand the current promotion of children's mental well-being in Chinese state legislation, school reform plans, and government statements. As we have seen, the psychological health of China's young is often conceived of as a means of strengthening the vitality of the Chinese nation, and of achieving a stable, "harmonious" society. In this type of society, old and young alike ideally are able to analyze and manage their personal problems through the use of rational psychological principles, while minimizing social strife and the need for brutal interventions on the part of the state. As Nikolas Rose has shown in the context of Western Europe and North America, the growth of the intellectual and practical technologies of psychology since the late nineteenth century has been intrinsically linked with transformations in the exercise of political power in contemporary liberal democracies (1996: 11). Arguably then, the current rise of psychological discourses of childrearing and education in urban China is closely related to—or indeed facilitates—the emergence of a new, neoliberal political program, which seeks to govern Chinese society through "the educated and informed choices of 'active' citizens, families, and communities" (Rose, 1996: 20; and see Tomba, 2009).

In making this particular claim, I follow in the footsteps of several other scholars, who have suggested that the current emphasis on the use of "scientific" child-rearing methods and on improving Chinese children's ability to display independence and "self-governance" may very well signify a move from an authoritarian, repressive governing mode to a Foucauldian "bio-power" in postsocialist, urban China (Greenhalgh and Winckler, 2005; Jing, 2000; Woronov, 2003). And yet, this article has also shown that in contemporary urban China, the promotion of "bio-political," "neoliberal" educational principles, which recommend the reform of individuals so that they are able to govern themselves (Dean, 1999: 210), is a complex and contradictory process.

It may be true that urban Chinese children, particularly those from affluent families, are now “tutored in the ways of conducting their lives” in order to promote the “necessary conditions for achieving social harmony through mental health” (Rose, 1989: 172), as has been the case in the modern, liberal democracies of Western Europe and North America (Rose, 1996; Walkerdine, 1984). It also may be the case that urban educated Chinese parents, who claim to possess “middle-class qualities,” are often the most eager to train their children to become civilized subjects, who presumably will help to create a “harmonious” society. Yet, it is also true that in postsocialist, urban China, the ascendance of a modern, so-called “bio-political” vision of the child and the person is nonetheless constrained by the deep-lying anxieties of both working-class and middle-class parents, as well as by the persistent influence of the ethos of filial piety, which prescribes an alternative notion of what constitutes a “proper, healthy” childhood.

Acknowledgments

I am grateful to Vanessa Fong and Terry Woronov for their valuable comments on an earlier version of the article.

Declaration of Conflicting Interests

The author(s) declared no conflicts of interest with respect to the authorship and/or publication of this article.

Funding

The author(s) disclosed receipt of the following financial support for the research and/or authorship of this article:

Writing this article was made possible by a Harry S. Truman and a Louis Frieberg Postdoctoral Fellowship.

Notes

1. Field (1995) and Cho (1995) note a similar trend in contemporary Japan and South Korea. In both countries, the intensive disciplining of children at school—through long hours of study, constant testing, the use of corporal punishment, and the monitoring of conduct—has reportedly caused an increase in children’s suicides, alongside the appearance of so-called “adult stress-related diseases” such as baldness and ulcers. These developments, Field (1995: 51–52) suggests, have led to a so-called “disappearance of childhood in Japan,” driven by “some of the same global forces that are responsible for the disappearance of childhood in the U.S.”
2. The phrase *suzhi jiaoyu* is sometimes translated as “quality education.” Following Woronov (2003) and Kipnis (2006), I prefer to use the term “education for quality,”

however, for as both scholars rightly observe, the latter phrase represents a more accurate rendering of the ultimate goals of the Chinese government's reform plan: raising the quality of China's population, not merely that of its education system. For a detailed account of this policy, and the reactions to its attempted implementation in primary schools in Beijing, see Woronov, 2008.

3. Arguably, such statements could also be regarded as a tactic of psychology experts in China, who seek to justify and legitimize their professional activities in the eyes of the government by employing the currently fashionable trope of "harmonious society."
4. As part of my study, I conducted close to 100 hours of participant-observations as well as intensive interviews with more than 40 staff and frontline teachers at two Shanghai primary schools. The first school was adjacent to one of Shanghai's top universities and served as an experimental base for educational research conducted there. Its teachers had relatively high qualifications, and many of its students came from families of university faculty and staff, or from middle-class families of means. The second school, located in a district of heavy industry and densely populated residential buildings, mainly catered to students from working-class families who lived nearby. A majority of this school's teachers did not have an academic degree, relying instead on a college or high school diploma.
5. My study included interviews with twenty Shanghai mothers, aged 33–52 years, whose children were aged 6–14 years. More than half of these mothers were highly educated, white-collar workers: three had at least a middle school education; two had a college diploma; nine had a bachelors' degree; and one possessed a PhD. In addition, I also interviewed two market vendors, two homemakers, and a former factory worker. Mothers of this group had relatively lower levels of education: While three had a middle school diploma, one had completed only nine years of schooling, while another—a recent migrant from the countryside—was a primary school graduate.
6. In her study on the implementation of "education for quality" reforms at primary schools in Beijing, Woronov (2008: 408) similarly notes that the demand that schools decrease children's workload frequently collided with pressures on Beijing's teachers to improve children's performances on standardized tests.
7. Woronov (2003, 2008) notes a similar phenomenon among "elite" Beijing parents.
8. According to recent statistics from China's MOE, about 10.2 million students applied to take the NCEE in June 2009. With only 6.29 million university and college places, the competition is indeed fierce. Even for those who actually make it to university, the competition continues to be tough even after graduation: at least 1 million graduates of the 5.6 million fresh out of university in 2008 failed to find employment. They joined graduates from previous years who were still unemployed (Xinhua News Agency, 2009).

9. These findings cannot be considered representative, of course, because of the small size of my sample. However, they largely correspond with the results of a large-scale 1998 survey on book reading habits conducted among 400 households in Shanghai, Tianjin, and Shenzhen (Wang et al., 2006). This particular study revealed that white-collar administrative workers and white-collar professionals with secondary or post-secondary education were much more likely to read books on children's education, compared with unskilled or semiskilled service workers, or self-employed workers of low levels of education, rural origins, and migrant backgrounds.
10. Woronov (2008) documents similar practices among the middle-class Beijing parents she interviewed.
11. Notably, studies on the consumption patterns of urban Chinese parents reveal that while city parents do tend to indulge their single child, toys rank relatively low in priority after items such as music and English language classes, computers, Western fast foods, and clothes (Croll, 2006: 180; Chan and McNeal, 2004: 140–43; see also Davis and Sensenbrenner, 2000). According to Croll, Chinese parents tend to regard toys primarily “as sources of enjoyment and recreation for children *up to age 7 years*, but from 7 to 8 years of age, play gives way to learning and only toys and games that are perceived to be educational aids tend to find favour with parents” (2006: 180, emphasis added).
12. In a similar fashion, a 42-year-old Beijing mother whose child spent a majority of her free time on her studies, reportedly explained to a *People's Daily* journalist that her 12-year-old daughter “will have plenty of time to play *after* she enters university” (*People's Daily*, 2007, emphasis added). In a recent study, Kipnis (2008: 214) likewise finds that Zouping urban and rural parents tend to limit the amount of housework and farm work their sons and daughters are expected to do, explicitly so that their children could “help them” by “studying hard and succeeding in school.”
13. In a recently published article, Ann Anagnost (2008: 65) further suggests that well-educated urban Chinese parents may be concerned about the effects of excessive regimentation on their child's “character” for fear it may damage his or her “value” as a “fully modern subject, one who is independent, self-confident, and fearless in confronting new situations.” None of the Shanghai parents I met with expressed their concerns for their child's suffering in quite such terms. Arguably, however, Anagnost's observation offers one possible explanation for the preoccupation with the current “crisis of childhood” among some well-educated Chinese parents.

References

- AFP (2004) “Nearly one-quarter of Shanghai's kids contemplate suicide.” 13 Oct. http://story.news.yahoo.com/news?tmpl=story&cid=1508&e=2&u=/afp/health_china_suicide (accessed Oct. 13, 2004).

- ANAGNOST, ANN (1997) "Children and national transcendence in China." Pp. 195–222 in Kenneth G. Lieberthal, Shuen-fu Lin, and Ernest P. Young (eds.), *Constructing China: The Interaction of Culture and Economics*. Ann Arbor: Center for Chinese Studies, Univ. of Michigan.
- (2004) "The corporeal politics of quality (suzhi)." *Public Culture* 16, 2: 189–208.
- (2008) "Imagining global futures in China: the child as a sign of value." Pp. 49–73 in Jennifer Cole and Deborah Durham (eds.), *Figuring the Future: Globalization and the Temporalities of Children and Youth*. Santa Fe, NM: School for Advanced Research Press.
- BAI, LIMIN (2005a) "Children at play: a childhood beyond the Confucian shadow." *Childhood* 12, 1: 9–32.
- (2005b) *Shaping the Ideal Child: Children and Their Primers in Late Imperial China*. Hong Kong: Chinese Univ. Press.
- BOREVSKAYA, NINA Y. (2001) "Searching for individuality: educational pursuits in China and Russia." Pp. 31–53 in Glen Peterson, Ruth Hayhoe, and Yongling Lu (eds.), *Education, Culture, and Identity in Twentieth-Century China*. Ann Arbor: Univ. of Michigan Press.
- BURMAN, ERICA (1996) "Local, global or globalized? Child development and international child rights legislation." *Childhood* 3: 45–66.
- CASS [Chinese Academy of Social Sciences] (2007) "Scholars discuss psychology and harmonious society." CASS News. 23 July. <http://english.cas.cn/english/news/detailnewsb.asp?InfoNo=26656> (accessed Oct. 20, 2008).
- CAST [China Association for Science and Technology] (2007) "Psychological Science Should Serve the Construction of A Harmonious Society, CAST Annual Meeting, Wuhan, 8–14 September, 2007." CAST News. 8 Sept. <http://english.cast.org.cn/n1181872/n1182018/n1182077/47809.html> (accessed Mar. 1, 2010).
- CHA, ARIANA EUNJUNG (2007) "In China, stern treatment for young internet 'addicts.'" *Washington Post*, 22 Feb.: AO1. www.washingtonpost.com/wp-dyn/content/article/2007/02/21/AR2007022102094_pf.html (accessed Oct. 28, 2008).
- CHAMPAGNE, SUSAN (1992) "Reproducing the Intelligent Child: Intelligence and the Child Rearing Discourse in the People's Republic of China." Ph.D. diss., Stanford Univ.
- CHAN, ANITA (1985) *Children of Mao: Personality Development and Political Activism in the Red Guard Generation*. London: Macmillan.
- CHAN, KARA and JAMES U. McNEAL (2004) *Advertising to Children in China*. Hong Kong: Chinese Univ. Press.
- CHANG, DORIS F., HUIQI TONG, QIJIA SHI, and QIFENG ZENG (2005) "Letting a hundred flowers bloom: counseling and psychotherapy in the People's Republic of China." *J. of Mental Health Counseling* 27, 2: 104–16.

- CHAO, RUTH. K. (1994) "Beyond parental control and authoritarian parenting style: understanding Chinese parenting through the cultural notion of training." *Child Development* 65, 4: 1111–19.
- CHEE, BERNADINE W. L. (2000) "Eating snacks and biting pressure: only children in Beijing." Pp. 48–70 in Jun Jing (ed.), *Feeding China's Little Emperors: Food, Children, and Social Change*. Stanford, CA: Stanford Univ. Press.
- China Daily (2004) "Kids: less study, more time for life." 26 May. www.china.org.cn/english/culture/96504.htm (accessed May 26, 2004).
- (2005) "Children lost in cyberspace." 7 Jan. <http://china.org.cn/english/Life/117105.htm> (accessed Jan. 7, 2005).
- (2010) "Mental health hotlines are coming." 20 Feb. <http://english.cast.org.cn/n1181872/n1182018/n1182078/11756466.html> (accessed Mar. 10, 2010).
- CHO, HAE-JOANG (1995) "Children in the examination war in South Korea: a cultural analysis." Pp. 141–68 in Sharon Stephens (ed.), *Children and the Politics of Culture*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton Univ. Press.
- Communist Party of China (2000) "The decision of the CPC Central Committee and the State Council on deepening education reform and promoting quality education in an all-around way (13 June 1999)." Pp. 230–41 in Robert J. Perrins (ed.), *China Facts and Figures Annual Handbook*. Vol. 25. Gulf Breeze, FL: Academic International Press.
- ROLL, ELISABETH J. (2006) *China's New Consumers: Social Development and Domestic Demand*. London: Routledge.
- CUI LIYING and HUANG YICHUN (2002) *Xinli suzhi jiaoyu lun* (Theories of psychological education for quality). Guangzhou: Guangdong jiaoyu chubanshe.
- CUI XIANGLU (1999) *Suzhi jiaoyu: zhongxiaoxue jiaoyu gaige de zhuxuanlü* (Education for quality: main themes of the primary and middle school education reforms). Ji'nan: Shandong jiaoyu chubanshe.
- DARDESS, JOHN (1991) "Childhood in premodern China." Pp. 71–94 in Joseph M. Hawes and N. Ray Hiner (eds.), *Children in Historical and Comparative Perspectives: An International Handbook and Research Guide*. New York: Greenwood.
- DAVIS, DEBORAH and JULIA S. SENSENBRENNER (2000) "Commercializing childhood: parental purchases for Shanghai's only child." Pp. 54–79 in Deborah S. Davis (ed.), *The Consumer Revolution in Urban China*. Berkeley: Univ. of California Press.
- DEAN, MITCHELL M. (1999) *Governmentality: Power and Rule in Modern Society*. London: SAGE Publications.
- DONALD, STEPHANIE H. (1999) "Children as political messengers: art, childhood, and continuity." Pp. 79–150 in Harriet Evans and Stephanie H. Donald (eds.), *Picturing Power in the People's Republic of China: Posters of the Cultural Revolution*. Lanham, MD: Rowman & Littlefield.

- DONALD, STEPHANIE H. and ZHENG YI (2008) "Richer than before—the cultivation of middle-class taste: education choices in urban China." Pp. 71–82 in David S. G. Goodman (ed.), *The New Rich in China: Future Rulers, Present Lives*. London: Routledge.
- ERWIN, KATHLYN (2000) "Heart-to-heart, phone-to-phone: family values, sexuality, and the politics of Shanghai's advice hotlines." Pp. 145–70 in Deborah S. Davis (ed.), *The Consumer Revolution in Urban China*. Berkeley: Univ. of California Press.
- FARQUHAR, JUDITH (2001) "For your reading pleasure: self-health (*ziwo baojian*) information in 1990s Beijing." *Positions: East Asia Cultures Critique* 9, 1: 105–30.
- FARQUHAR, MARY ANN (1999) *Children's Literature in China: From Lu Xun to Mao Zedong*. Armonk, NY: M.E. Sharpe.
- FENG, JIAN (2003) "The doctor is in." *Beijing Rev.* 46, 33: 10–13.
- FERNSEBNER, SUSAN R. (2003) "A people's playthings: toys, childhood, and Chinese identity, 1909–1933." *Postcolonial Studies* 6, 3: 269–93.
- FIELD, NORMA (1995) "The child as laborer and consumer: the disappearance of childhood in contemporary Japan." Pp. 51–78 in Sharon Stephens (ed.), *Children and the Politics of Culture*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton Univ. Press.
- FONG, VANESSA L. (2004a) "Filial nationalism among Chinese teenagers with global identities." *American Ethnologist* 31, 4: 631–48.
- (2004b) *Only Hope: Coming of Age under China's One-Child Policy*. Stanford, CA: Stanford Univ. Press.
- (2007) "Parent-child communication problems and the perceived inadequacies of Chinese only children." *Ethos* 35, 1: 85–127.
- FU DAOQUN and XU CHANGJIANG (2001) *Xin kecheng yu jiaoshi juese zhuanbian* (The new curriculum and the transformation of the teacher's role). Beijing: Jiaoyu kexue chubanshe.
- GREENHALGH, SUSAN and EDWIN A. WINCKLER (2005) *Governing China's Population: From Leninist to Neoliberal Biopolitics*. Stanford, CA: Stanford Univ. Press.
- GUAN, XIAOMENG (2009) "'Spoiled generation' paves way for new age parenting." *China Daily*, 14 July. http://www.chinadaily.com.cn/china/2009-07/14/content_8427903.htm (accessed July 19, 2009).
- Guangdong sheng kepu xinxi zhongxin [Guangdong Province Popular Science Information Center] (2008) "Xinli jiankang yu hexie shehui (Mental health and harmonious society). http://ycqkj.gov.cn/book.asp?t_id=604 (accessed May 1, 2010).
- GUO, ZI (2004) "Education aimed at building the whole person." *China Daily*, 26 Oct.: 6.
- HE DONGLIANG (2007) "Xinlixue shiye xia de hexie shehui" (Harmonious society from the perspective of psychology). Changshu sheke wang, Changshushi zhexue shehui kexuejie lianhehui. 5 Nov. [www.cssa.gov.cn/skl disp/skl/skl_message .asp?id=499](http://www.cssa.gov.cn/skl disp/skl/skl_message.asp?id=499) (accessed June 10, 2009).

- HEYWOOD, COLIN (2001) *A History of Childhood: Children and Childhood in the West from Medieval to Modern Times*. Oxford: Polity.
- HSIUNG, PING-CHEN (2005) *A Tender Voyage: Children and Childhood in Late Imperial China*. Stanford, CA: Stanford Univ. Press.
- JAMES, ALLISON, CHRIS JENKS, and ALAN PROUT (1998) *Theorizing Childhood*. Cambridge, UK: Polity.
- JING, JUN (2000) "Food, children, and social change in contemporary China." Pp. 1–26 in Jun Jing (ed.), *Feeding China's Little Emperors: Food, Children and Social Change*. Stanford, CA: Stanford Univ. Press.
- JONES, ANDREW F. (2002) "The child as history in Republican China: a discourse on development." *Positions: East Asia Cultures Critique* 10, 3: 695–727.
- KINNEY, ANNE BEHNKE (1995) "Introduction." Pp. 1–14 in Anne Behnke Kinney (ed.), *Chinese Views of Childhood*. Honolulu: Univ. of Hawai'i Press
- (2004) *Representations of Childhood and Youth in Early China*. Stanford, CA: Stanford Univ. Press.
- KIPNIS, ANDREW (2006) "Suzhi: a keyword approach." *China Q.* 186: 1–24.
- (2008) "Education and the governing of child-centered relatedness." Pp. 204–22 in Susan Brandtstädter and Gonçalo D. Santos (eds.), *Chinese Kinship: Contemporary Anthropological Perspectives*. London: Routledge.
- LEUNG, ANGELA K. C. (1995) "Relief institutions for children in nineteenth-century China." Pp. 251–78 in Anne Behnke Kinney (ed.), *Chinese Views of Childhood*. Honolulu: Univ. of Hawai'i Press.
- LIU, FAN (1982) "Developmental psychology in China." *Intl. J. of Behavioral Development* 5: 391–411.
- MILWERTZ, CECILIA N. (1997) *Accepting Population Control: Urban Chinese Women and the One-Child Family Policy*. Richmond, UK: Curzon.
- NAFTALI, ORNA (2008) "Treating students as subjects: globalization, childhood and education in contemporary China." Pp. 251–74 in Julia Resnik (ed.), *The Production of Educational Knowledge in the Global Era*. Rotterdam: Sense Publishers.
- (2009) "Empowering the child: children's rights, citizenship and the state in contemporary China." *China J.* 61: 79–104.
- NYLAN, MICHAEL (2003) "Childhood, formal education, and ideology in China." Pp. 136–58 in Willem Koops and Michael Zuckerman (eds.), *Beyond the Century of the Child: Cultural History and Developmental Psychology*. Philadelphia: Univ. of Pennsylvania Press.
- PEASE, CATHERINE E. (1995) "Remembering the taste of melons: modern Chinese stories of childhood." Pp. 279–320 in Anne Behnke Kinney (ed.) *Chinese Views of Childhood*. Honolulu: Univ. of Hawai'i Press.
- People's Daily (2005) "China works to create well-rounded college students." 7 June. http://english.people.com.cn/200506/07/eng20050607_188929.html (accessed June 7, 2005).

- (2007) "China's children too busy for playtime." 13 May. http://english.people.com.cn/200705/13/eng20070513_374164.html (accessed May 13, 2007).
- REYNOLDS, JAMES (2008) "Chinese youth 'face suicide risk.'" BBC News. 10 Sept. <http://news.bbc.co.uk/go/pr/fr/-/2/hi/asia-pacific/7608575.stm/> (accessed Sept. 10, 2008).
- ROSE, NIKOLAS (1989) *Governing the Soul: The Shaping of the Private Self*. London: Routledge.
- (1996) *Inventing Our Selves: Psychology, Power, and Personhood*. Cambridge, UK: Cambridge Univ. Press
- SAARI, JON L. (1990) *Legacies of Childhood: Growing Up Chinese in a Time of Crisis, 1890–1920*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard Univ. Press.
- SCHEPER-HUGHES, NANCY and CAROLYN SARGENT (1998) "Introduction: the cultural politics of childhood." Pp. 1–33 in Nancy Scheper-Hughes and Carolyn Sargent (eds.), *Small Wars: The Cultural Politics of Childhood*. Berkeley: Univ. of California Press.
- Shanghai People's Congress Standing Committee [Shanghai shi renmin daibiao dahui changwu weiyuanhui] (2004) Shanghai shi weichengnian ren baohu tiaoli (Shanghai municipality regulations on the protection of minors). www.shmec.gov.cn/xxgk/PubInfo/rows_content.php?article_code=201042005001 (accessed Dec. 1, 2005).
- STAFFORD, CHARLES (1995) *The Roads of Chinese Childhood: Learning and Identification in Angang*. Cambridge, UK: Cambridge Univ. Press.
- STEPHENS, SHARON (1995) "Introduction: children and the politics of culture in 'late capitalism.'" Pp. 3–48 in Sharon Stephens (ed.), *Children and the Politics of Culture*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton Univ. Press.
- SUN LICHUN (2001) *Suzhi jiaoyu xin lun* (New theories of education for quality). Ji'nan: Shandong jiaoyu chubanshe.
- TARDIF, TWILLA and MIAO XIAOCHUN (2000) "Developmental psychology in China." *Intl. J. of Behavioral Development* 24, 1: 68–72.
- TIAN DOUDOU (2005) "Yinian lai ta zai quanguo gedi zuole 300 duo chang baogao, miandui mian zhidaole chengqian shangwan de jiazhang he haizi—Tao Hongkai: yu 'wangyin' zhengduo haizi" (Tao Hongkai helps children with "internet addiction": this year he has given more than 300 field lectures and provided face-to-face guidance to thousands of parents and children across the country). *Renmin ribao*, 23 May: 11.
- TOMBA, LUIGI (2009) "Of quality, harmony, and community: civilization and the middle class in urban China." *Positions: East Asia Cultures Critique* 17, 3 (Winter 2009): 592–616.
- WALKERDINE, VALERIE (1984) "Developmental psychology and the child-centered pedagogy: the insertion of Piaget into early education." Pp. 153–202 in Julia Henriques et al. (eds.), *Changing the Subject: Psychology, Social Regulation and Subjectivity*. London: Methuen.

- (2005) "Developmental psychology and the study of childhood." Pp. 13–25 in Chris Jenks (ed.), *Childhood: Critical Concepts in Sociology*. Vol. 3. New York: Routledge.
- WANG, SHAOGUANG, DEBORAH DAVIS, and BIAN YANJIE (2006) "The uneven distribution of cultural capital: book reading in urban China." *Modern China* 32, 3 (July): 315–48.
- WANG PENG (2002) *Zai jiating jiaoyu zhong zouchu ertong guan de wuqu* (Avoiding erroneous views of the child in family education). Pp. 104–3 in *Jiaoyu bu jichu jiaoyu si, Quanguo fulian ertong gongzuo bu, Gong qingtuan zhongyang shaonian bu* (MOE Basic Education Department, ACWF Children's Work Department, and the Communist Youth League Central Youth Department) (eds.), *Geng xin jiating jiaoyu guannian baogaoji* (Report on new views of family education). Beijing: Zhongguo fazhi chubanshe.
- WEI ZONGXUAN [ed.] (2000) *Xiaoxue suzhi jiaoyu* (Education for quality in primary schools). Changsha: Hunan renmin chubanshe.
- WHYTE, MARTIN KING (2004) "Filial obligations in Chinese families: paradoxes of modernization." Pp. 106–27 in Charlotte Ikels (ed.), *Filial Piety: Practice and Discourse in Contemporary East Asia*. Stanford, CA: Stanford Univ. Press.
- WICKS, ANN BARROTT and ELLEN B. AVRIL (2002) "Introduction: children in Chinese art." Pp. 1–30 in Anne Barrott Wicks (ed.), *Children in Chinese Art*. Honolulu: Univ. of Hawai'i Press.
- WOODHEAD, MARTIN (1997) "Psychology and the cultural construction of children's needs." Pp. 63–84 in Allison James and Alan Prout (eds.), *Constructing and Reconstructing Childhood: Contemporary Issues in the Sociological Study of Childhood*. London: Falmer.
- WORONOV, TERRY E. (2003) "Transforming the Future: 'Quality' Children for the Chinese Nation." Ph.D. diss., Univ. of Chicago.
- (2007) "Chinese children, American education: globalizing childrearing in contemporary China." Pp. 29–51 in Jennifer Cole and Deborah Durham (eds.), *Generations and Globalization: Youth, Age, and Family in the New World Economy*. Bloomington: Indiana Univ. Press.
- (2008) "Raising quality, fostering 'creativity': ideologies and practices of education reform in Beijing," *Anthropology and Education Q.* 38, 4: 401–22.
- WU, DAVID Y. H. (1996) "Parental control: psychocultural interpretations of Chinese patterns of socialization." Pp. 1–26 in Sing Lau (ed.), *Growing Up the Chinese Way: Chinese Child and Adolescent Development*. Hong Kong: Chinese Univ. Press.
- Xiaoxuesheng xinli suzhi peiyang: si nianji jiaoshi yongshu [Nurturing the psychological quality of primary school students: fourth-grade teacher's manual] (2000) Primary and Middle School Psychological Health Education Study Group, and the Psychological Quality Education Research Center (eds.). Beijing: Kaiming chubanshe.

- Xinhua News Agency (2003) "Beijing protects minors through law." 6 Dec. www.china.org.cn/english/2003/Dec/81723.htm (accessed Mar. 20, 2005).
- (2008) "Psychological education to cover schools." 6 Feb. www.china.org.cn/2008-02/06/content_1242267.htm (accessed Oct. 10, 2008).
- (2009) "10 million sit China's college entrance exams amid cheating, flu concerns." 6 June. www.chinadaily.com.cn/china/2009-06/07/content_8257288.htm (accessed June 6, 2009).
- XU SHAN (2004) "Qing fangshou, gei haizi fuze de rensheng taidu" (Let go, so that your child can have a responsible attitude in life). *Weile haizi* 12B: 13.
- YANG, LIFEI (2004) "Students get to sleep later: primary classes shortened, lunch break extended." *Shanghai Daily*, 28–29 Aug.: 2.
- ZENG QI [ed.] (2004) *Xin kecheng yu jiaoshi xinli tiaoshi* (The new curriculum and the emotional adjustment of teachers). Beijing: Jiaoyu kexue chubanshe.
- ZHANG, LI (2008) "China's ascent as a theoretical question." *Anthropology News* 49, 8: 13.
- ZHANG, YANHUA and ZHOU RONG (2008) "System construction on psychological harmony education of college students [sic]." *US-China Education Rev.* 5, 3: 49–53.
- ZHOU FENG (1998) *Suzhi jiaoyu: lilun, caozuo, jingyan* (Education for quality: theory, operation, and experience). Huizhou: Guangdong renmin chubanshe.
- ZHOU SHIZHANG (2005) "Dui Shanghai zhongxiaoxue erqi kegai de renshi yu sikao" (Reflections on Shanghai's second phase curriculum reform). In *Shanghai shi jiaoshi jiaoyu wang* (Shanghai's teachers and education network). www.21shte.net/teachforum/hezuomeiti/pdij-1.htm (accessed Mar. 23, 2005).

Biography

Orna Naftali is a research fellow at the Harry S. Truman Research Institute for the Advancement of Peace and the Louis Frieberg Center for East Asian Studies at the Hebrew University of Jerusalem. Her most recent publication is "Empowering the Child: Children's Rights, Citizenship, and the State in Contemporary China" (*China Journal*, 2009). She is currently completing a book on childhood, modernity, and the nation-state in the People's Republic of China.